

Round-Trip Rate Cards

Why every nearby outstation destination is currently priced the same, and how to correct it from the admin portal.

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Formula verified against `api/src/lib/fare.ts` (round-trip branch); seeded values against `016_seed.sql` and `074_round_trip_package_billing.sql`.

REPORTED ISSUE

“Round trip Outstation ride fares showing same for Bhubaneswar and Puri also. So it’s not calculating properly.”

SUMMARY

The calculation is correct. The configuration is not. Round trips are billed on a guaranteed-minimum-kilometre package — the same model Ola Outstation and comparable operators use. That package is currently set to **250 km per day for every vehicle category**, a placeholder inserted during setup and never replaced with real numbers. The practical effect: **every destination within roughly 125 km of the pickup point returns an identical fare**, because the whole round trip fits inside the package. **The fix is a data change in the admin portal — no code change, no deployment.**

1. Which ride type covers which journey

This document concerns **round trips only**. Ocar has three ride types and they serve different journeys, so it is worth being precise about the boundary before looking at fares.

Ride type	Serves	Billing basis
Rental	Journeys that begin and end inside the same city zone	Hourly/kilometre packages from <code>rental_packages</code> — a separate configuration, not covered here.
One way	Intercity, single leg	Per kilometre plus per minute.
Round trip	Intercity, out and back	Guaranteed-minimum-kilometre package plus driver allowance. This document.

A journey is treated as intercity only when pickup and drop do *not* both fall inside the same city boundary. That check lives in `classifyTrip()`, which returns either `in_city` or `outstation`.

BHUBANESWAR, CUTTACK AND KHORDHA ARE ONE ZONE

These three are deliberately configured as a **single merged city boundary**, not three separate cities. Any journey between them therefore classifies as `in_city` and is served by **rental**, not by round trip. They are consequently **not used as examples anywhere in this document** — a Bhubaneswar-Cuttack round trip is not an outstation booking and is not priced by the rate cards discussed here.

Every route used below is a genuine outstation destination: a separately configured city outside that merged zone.

2. How a round-trip fare is built

A round-trip outstation booking is not billed purely per kilometre driven. It is billed as a **package**: a guaranteed minimum distance per day that the customer pays for whether or not they travel that far, plus a flat daily allowance for the driver, plus any distance driven *beyond* the package (“overage”).

The package exists to protect the driver. A driver who commits a full day to an outstation trip should not be paid as though it were a short hop. The package sets a floor under that day’s earnings.

```
# api/src/lib/fare.ts – round_trip branch

days = max(1, ceil(trip_hours / 24)) // trip_hours is floored at 4 upstream
packageKm = days × km_per_day
overageKm = max(0, estimated_km – packageKm)

distance_fare = packageKm × rate_per_km
overage_fare = overageKm × rate_per_km
metered = distance_fare + overage_fare
floored = max(metered, min_fare)
subtotal = floored + stop_fare + (days × driver_allowance_per_day)
total = subtotal × surge_multiplier

# The two metered lines reduce to a single idea:
# metered = max(estimated_km, packageKm) × rate_per_km
# You pay for the package, or for the real distance – whichever is larger.
```

Two details that matter and are easy to miss:

- **estimated_km is the total to-and-fro distance**, not the one-way leg. Puri is a 64 km leg, so estimated_km = 128. The doubling happens in pricing.service.ts before the fare engine runs.
- **Surge multiplies the whole subtotal**, including the driver allowance — not just the distance component.

3. Why nearby destinations all return the same fare

With km_per_day = 250 on a single-day trip, the package is 250 km of *round-trip* distance. That covers any destination up to **125 km away**. Puri, Jajpur and Paradeep are all inside that radius, so all three are billed for the full 250 km package, none generates overage, and the actual distance never enters the calculation.

Sedan · single day	Puri 64 km each way	Jajpur 98 km each way	Paradeep 105 km each way
Actual distance (to and fro)	128 km	196 km	210 km
Package (1 day × 250 km)	250 km	250 km	250 km
Overage beyond package	0 km	0 km	0 km
Distance fare (250 × ₹13)	₹3,250	₹3,250	₹3,250
Overage fare	₹0	₹0	₹0
Driver allowance (1 × ₹300)	₹300	₹300	₹300
Total charged	₹3,550	₹3,550	₹3,550

The same collapse happens in every vehicle category. Balasore is included as a control: at 392 km round trip it exceeds the package, so it does price differently — which confirms the engine works correctly and only the package size is wrong.

Category	Rate/km	Puri 128 km	Jajpur 196 km	Paradeep 210 km	Balasore 392 km
Hatchback	₹10	₹2,800	₹2,800	₹2,800	₹4,220
Sedan	₹13	₹3,550	₹3,550	₹3,550	₹5,396
SUV	₹17	₹4,550	₹4,550	₹4,550	₹6,964
Luxury	₹25	₹6,550	₹6,550	₹6,550	₹10,100
Van	₹16	₹4,300	₹4,300	₹4,300	₹6,572

Round-trip distances are twice the approximate one-way road distance. Single-day bookings, no stops, no surge. Produced by executing the formula above. Approximate road distances are for illustration; the platform bills the actual routed distance.

4. Is this pricing model correct?

Yes. The guaranteed-minimum-kilometre package is the standard commercial model for outstation cabs in India, not an invention of this platform. Ola Outstation bills a **minimum of 250 km per day** for sedans at roughly ₹11-15/km, with a mandatory driver allowance (*batta*) of ₹300-500 per day on top, plus GST and surge. Savaari and other established operators price the same way.

THE DISTINCTION THAT MATTERS

The 250 km/day figure is genuine industry practice — **for the trips it was designed for**. It protects a driver on a long interstate run of 400 km or more, often spanning several days. It was never intended for a 64 km regional hop. Ocar inherited the number without inheriting the context: **the model is right, the parameter is wrong for this market**. Odisha's coastal corridor puts most demand well inside a 125 km radius, which is precisely the range the current setting flattens.

Cross-check against the live market

Published fares for a Bhubaneswar-Puri same-day round trip by sedan sit in the **₹1,700-₹2,200** band. Ocar currently quotes ₹3,550 — roughly 60-100 % above the market.

Source	Vehicle	Puri round-trip fare
MakeMyTrip	Sedan	₹1,714
CabBazar (same-day return, 10-12 h)	Sedan	₹2,180
CabBazar (same-day return, 10-12 h)	SUV	₹3,021
Ocar today	Sedan	₹3,550
Ocar after correction	Sedan	₹1,964

So the misconfiguration is not only collapsing price differences between destinations — it is also pricing the platform out of its own market on its single busiest route.

5. Choosing the right package size

The rule: **the package must be smaller than the shortest round trip you actually sell**. Only then does real distance drive the price. If the package is larger, every trip beneath it collapses to the same fare. Ocar's shortest outstation round trip is Puri at 128 km, so the package must sit below 128.

km_per_day	Puri 128 km	Jajpur 196 km	Paradeep 210 km	Balasore 392 km	Distinct prices
250 (<i>today</i>)	₹3,550	₹3,550	₹3,550	₹5,396	2 of 4
210	₹3,030	₹3,030	₹3,030	₹5,396	2 of 4
196	₹2,848	₹2,848	₹3,030	₹5,396	3 of 4
150	₹2,250	₹2,848	₹3,030	₹5,396	4 of 4
128	₹1,964	₹2,848	₹3,030	₹5,396	4 of 4
64	₹1,964	₹2,848	₹3,030	₹5,396	4 of 4
40	₹1,964	₹2,848	₹3,030	₹5,396	4 of 4

READ THIS TABLE CAREFULLY

At or below 128 km the fares stop changing. Once the package is smaller than every real route, actual distance is doing all the work and the exact package value no longer affects these trips. Its only remaining job is to protect the driver on an unusually short booking. That means **you do not need to find a precise number** — you need a number safely below your shortest sellable round trip.

Note also that **Balasore never moves**: ₹5,396 at every setting. Long trips already bill on real distance and are unaffected by this change.

A TRAP WORTH AVOIDING

Lowering the package from 250 to 200 would look like a fix and would not be one. Puri, Jajpur and Paradeep would *still* all fall inside a 200 km package and still bill identically — the original complaint, reproduced at a lower price. Even 196 leaves Puri and Jajpur tied. Always check a proposed value against your **shortest** route, not your longest.

6. Suggested values

These are a defensible starting point, not a commercial instruction. They place every category well below the shortest live route while keeping a meaningful floor for short bookings. Final numbers are a pricing decision for the business.

Category	Package KM/day now → suggested	Driver Allowance/day	Puri	Jajpur	Paradeep	Balasore
Hatchback	250 → 40	₹300	₹1,580	₹2,260	₹2,400	₹4,220
Sedan	250 → 40	₹300	₹1,964	₹2,848	₹3,030	₹5,396
SUV	250 → 40	₹350	₹2,526	₹3,682	₹3,920	₹7,014
Luxury	250 → 40	₹400	₹3,600	₹5,300	₹5,650	₹10,200
Van	250 → 40	₹300	₹2,348	₹3,436	₹3,660	₹6,572

A single package value of 40 km across all categories is deliberate: below the differentiation threshold the value stops affecting these routes, so varying it per category adds configuration surface without changing any price. Category differentiation comes from `rate_per_km` and the driver allowance, which is where it belongs. Only the allowances for SUV and Luxury are proposed to change.

THIS IS A REVENUE CHANGE, NOT ONLY A BUG FIX

Correcting the package cuts the quoted sedan Puri fare from ₹3,550 to ₹1,964 — about 45 % lower — and Puri is likely the highest-volume outstation route on the platform. That is the intended outcome, since the current figure is well above market and was never deliberately chosen. It should nonetheless be signed off by whoever owns pricing before it is applied, not treated as a silent technical correction.

7. How to change it

The values live in the `rate_cards` table and are editable from the admin portal. No deployment, no migration, no engineering involvement.

1. Sign in to the admin portal and open **Config → Rate Cards** (`/config/rate-cards`).
2. Find the row for the vehicle category you want, with ride type **Round Trip**, and open it. The dialog is titled `Update <Category> · Round Trip`.
3. Leave **City** as *All Cities (Global Default)* unless you specifically want a single-city override — see the caution below.
4. Edit **Package KM/day**. This is `km_per_day`. The field shows the current value beneath it as *was 250*.
5. Adjust **Driver Allowance/day (₹)** if required. This is `driver_allowance_per_day`.
6. Fill in **Change Reason** — mandatory, and written to the rate-card history as the audit record for this change.
7. Save. Repeat for each of the five categories.

WHAT HAPPENS WHEN YOU SAVE

Nothing is overwritten. Rate cards are versioned: saving expires the current row and inserts a new one, so previous pricing stays on record. The dialog states this directly — *“Creates a new rate card and expires the current one. All future rides use the new rate.”*

Rides already booked are unaffected. Every booking freezes its own fare breakdown in a fare snapshot at the moment of booking, so in-flight and completed rides keep the price the customer agreed to. Only estimates requested after the save use the new values.

CAUTION: A CITY OVERRIDE WILL NOT SOLVE THIS

The **City** dropdown scopes a rate card to a single city, and it is matched on the **pickup** city only — the destination is not part of the lookup. A Bhubaneswar override therefore applies identically to a Bhubaneswar-Puri trip and a Bhubaneswar-Balasore trip. City overrides answer “fares starting in Berhampur differ from fares starting in Bhubaneswar”, not “further destinations should cost more”. Distance already handles the second case once the package is set correctly.

8. What to expect afterwards

Change	Effect
Nearby destinations price distinctly	The reported symptom disappears. Puri, Jajpur and Paradeep separate in proportion to real distance instead of collapsing to one figure.
Short outstation trips get cheaper	Puri was being charged for 250 km against an actual 128 km. This is the largest single correction and affects the highest-volume route.
Long trips do not move at all	Balasore stays at ₹5,396. Anything already exceeding the package was always billing on real distance.
Very short bookings still hit a floor	A trip under the package still bills at the package. Deliberate driver protection, not a residual bug.
Nothing changes retroactively	Completed and in-progress rides keep their snapshotted fares.
Rental pricing is untouched	In-city journeys are billed from rental_packages and are not affected by any change described here.

How to verify the fix

1. Save the new values for one category — Sedan is easiest to check.
2. In the rider app, request round-trip estimates to **two different outstation destinations** at clearly different distances — for example Puri and Paradeep.
3. Confirm they now return different fares, and that Puri lands near the ₹1,964 shown above. Small differences are expected: the real routed distance will not be exactly 128 km, and any active surge multiplies the total.
4. Repeat for the remaining categories.

ONE RELATED ITEM, LISTED SEPARATELY

The second issue reported the same day — Khordha pickups classifying as outstation rather than in-city — is a **different and unrelated fault**, caused by a city-boundary migration overwriting an earlier deliberate merged boundary. It requires a code change and a deployment, and is not affected by anything in this document. Once corrected, Khordha journeys to Bhubaneswar or Cuttack return to being in-city and are served by rental rather than round trip.

All fares were produced by executing the round-trip branch of `api/src/lib/fare.ts` against the seeded rate-card values, for single-day bookings with no stops and no surge active. One-way road distances are approximate and used only to illustrate; the platform bills actual routed distance. Market comparison figures are published third-party fares at the time of writing and will move.